

The Ultimate Modesto ADU Permit Cheat Sheet

Modesto, Stanislaus County — 2026

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The information provided is strictly for educational purposes and does not constitute legal, architectural, or professional urban planning advice. Always consult the official city planning department before making any decisions or starting any construction project.

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■ Modesto ADU — Key Regulations & Local Contacts

Zoning Rules Overview

Regulation	Requirement
Maximum Size	1,200 sq ft for a detached ADU, which also cannot exceed the main home's floor area; an attached ADU is capped at 50% of the main home but never below 800 sq ft; a JADU is limited to 500 sq ft sq ft
Property Setbacks	At least 4 ft side and 4 ft rear for a new detached ADU; a converted structure only needs enough clearance for fire and safety; lot coverage limits do not apply to an ADU of 800 sq ft or less

■ Local Planning Department

Department: Planning & Building Department

Phone: (209) 577-5200

Email: planning@modestogov.com

Address: 1010 10th St, Modesto, CA 95354

Hours: Check website

■ Key Online Resources

- **ADU Information:** <https://www.modestogov.com>
- **Zoning Map:** <https://www.modestogov.com/145/Zoning>
- **Permit Portal:** <https://www.modestogov.com/272/Building-Permits>

■ Maximum Estimated Permit Fees

- Building permit fee: \$1,500
- Impact / development fees: \$5,000
- Plan check fee: \$800

■ Modesto ADU — Step-by-Step Project Checklist

- Verify zoning compliance — confirm your lot is zoned for ADU use
- Check the official zoning map at: <https://www.modestogov.com/145/Zoning>
- Measure lot size, setbacks, and height limits against your design
- Prepare a preliminary site plan (property lines, building locations, setbacks)
- Draft floor plan showing ADU layout (bedroom, kitchen, bathroom)
- Complete the building permit application — available at:
<https://www.modestogov.com/272/Building-Permits>
- Gather required documents: site plan, floor plan, elevations, proof of ownership
- Submit complete application package to the Planning Department in person or online
- Pay plan check fee and building permit fee
- Wait for plan review (typically 4-8 weeks — respond to correction notices promptly)
- Schedule required inspections: foundation, framing, electrical, plumbing, final
- Obtain Certificate of Occupancy once all inspections pass

■ *Tip: Schedule a pre-application meeting with the Modesto Planning Department early in your process — they can identify issues before you spend time and money on detailed plans.*